

CERTIFIED CIGAR SOMMELIER (CCS®)

MODULE 3 TEACHING MANUAL

THE PEAK-FLAVOUR FRAMEWORK

Status: Core Module – Mandatory

Applies to: CCS® Level I & ACS® Level II

Estimated Study Load: 3 Hours

MODULE PURPOSE

In previous modules, candidates learned that:

- combustion temperature affects flavour delivery,
- tobacco moisture affects combustion behaviour,
- and cigars respond differently at different humidity levels.

This module brings those concepts together into a practical professional system known as the **Peak-Flavour Framework**.

The purpose of this framework is to help the sommelier identify the humidity range where a cigar performs at its highest flavour potential.

By the end of this module, candidates should understand:

- why cigars taste dramatically different at different RH levels,
- why small humidity changes matter,
- how to identify under- or over-humidified cigars,
- and how professionals manage cigars into their optimal smoking condition.

This module moves cigar evaluation away from:

“I like this cigar.”

and toward:

“This cigar is performing correctly - and here is why.”

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this module, the candidate shall be able to:

1. Define Peak-Flavour RH accurately
2. Explain why peak flavour exists within narrow humidity windows

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3. Distinguish flavour balance from strength or aroma intensity
 4. Predict flavour failure above and below peak RH
 5. Apply the framework across different cigar constructions
 6. Explain why different cigars require different RH targets
 7. Diagnose disappointing cigar performance professionally
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SECTION 1

UNDERSTANDING PEAK FLAVOUR

Why This Matters Professionally

Many smokers assume that:

- stronger cigars are better cigars,

- smoother cigars are properly humidified,
- or premium brands automatically smoke perfectly.

Professional cigar service requires a more accurate approach.

A cigar may be:

- expensive,
- strong,
- smooth,
- or aromatic,

while still performing outside its ideal flavour condition.

The role of the sommelier is to identify when the cigar is operating at its intended flavour balance.

1.1 What Is Peak-Flavour RH?

Peak-Flavour RH is the relative humidity level where:

- combustion temperature,
- tobacco moisture,
- and flavour-compound release

work together most efficiently to produce balanced flavour expression.

At this point, the cigar delivers:

- optimal sweetness,
- controlled strength,
- clean aroma delivery,
- stable combustion,
- and coherent flavour progression.

Peak flavour is generally:

- cigar-specific,
- narrow in range,
- repeatable,
- and measurable through smoking performance.

1.2 What Peak Flavour Is NOT

Peak flavour does not simply mean:

- maximum strength,
- maximum smoke output,
- highest nicotine impact,
- strongest aroma,
- or the blender's storage recommendation.

These characteristics may sometimes overlap with peak flavour, but they are not the same thing.

A cigar can feel:

- powerful,
- smooth,
- or aromatic,

while still being outside its optimal performance range.

1.3 Why Peak Flavour Exists

From earlier modules, candidates learned that:

- combustion occurs within temperature ranges,
- flavour compounds release at different temperatures,
- moisture affects combustion speed,
- and tobacco reacts non-linearly to humidity.

This means there must be a humidity range where:

- heat,
- moisture,
- and flavour release

become properly balanced.

This balanced state is known as **peak flavour**.

Professionally, peak flavour is treated as:

a combustion and moisture alignment condition,
not merely personal preference.

SECTION 2

THE PEAK-FLAVOUR ALIGNMENT MODEL

Why This Matters Professionally

When cigars perform poorly, smokers often blame:

- the brand,
- the factory,
- or the blend itself.

In reality, many flavour problems are caused by incorrect humidity alignment.

Understanding the alignment model allows the sommelier to diagnose problems accurately.

2.1 The Three-Variable Alignment

Peak flavour occurs when three critical variables align simultaneously:

1. Combustion Temperature
2. Water Activity Inside the Leaf
3. Volatile Flavour Compound Release

If one variable falls outside the correct range, flavour balance begins to collapse.

2.2 Combustion Temperature Alignment

If the cigar is too dry:

- combustion becomes excessively hot,
- smoke becomes sharper,
- sweetness declines,
- and delicate aromatics may burn away.

If the cigar is too wet:

- combustion becomes too cool,

- flavour release weakens,
- smoke becomes dull,
- and combustion efficiency decreases.

Peak flavour exists between these two extremes.

2.3 Water Activity Alignment

Not all moisture inside tobacco behaves the same way.

The cigar requires enough functional moisture to:

- regulate combustion,
- support pyrolysis,
- and buffer smoke chemistry.

Too little moisture:

- sugars carbonize too aggressively,
- bitterness increases,
- combustion becomes unstable.

Too much moisture:

- pyrolysis efficiency drops,
- flavour release weakens,
- combustion becomes sluggish.

Professional humidification is therefore not about maximizing moisture.

It is about controlling moisture precisely.

2.4 Volatile Compound Release

Flavour compounds release at different combustion temperatures.

Some compounds:

- vaporize easily,
- while others require more moderated heat.

Humidity affects:

- when compounds release,
- how long they survive,
- and whether they degrade before reaching the smoker.

This is why humidity dramatically changes:

- sweetness,
- aroma clarity,
- spice balance,
- smoke texture,
- and flavour complexity.

SECTION 3

WHY THE PEAK-FLAVOUR WINDOW IS NARROW

3.1 Non-Linear Tobacco Response

Tobacco does not react to RH changes in a simple linear way.

Within normal smoking ranges, even small humidity adjustments can significantly alter:

- combustion temperature,
- smoke texture,
- flavour release,
- and nicotine delivery.

This explains why:

- a cigar at 62% RH may perform very differently from the same cigar at 65% RH.

Professionally:

“close enough” is often not precise enough.

3.2 Why $\pm 1\%$ RH Matters

Within approximately $\pm 1\%$ of peak RH:

- combustion usually remains controlled,

- flavour remains balanced,
- and degradation occurs gradually.

Outside this range:

- imbalance accelerates,
- flavour distortion increases,
- and combustion efficiency declines rapidly.

Professional implication:

Precision matters more than average humidity.

Common Student Mistake

Many beginners believe:

“Any cigar stored between 65–72% RH should smoke the same.”

This is incorrect.

Different cigars:

- respond differently to moisture,
- burn differently,
- and reach peak flavour at different RH levels.

SECTION 4

PEAK FLAVOUR VS PERCEIVED QUALITY

Why This Matters Professionally

Many smokers confuse:

- strength,
- smoothness,
- or smoke density

with cigar quality.

A sommelier must learn to evaluate:

- balance,
 - combustion behaviour,
 - flavour clarity,
 - and progression instead.
-

4.1 Why Dry Cigars Feel Stronger

Dry cigars often:

- burn hotter,
- release nicotine more aggressively,
- produce sharper smoke,
- and increase pepper sensation.

This can create the illusion of:

- strength,
- intensity,
- or richness.

However, excessive combustion heat frequently destroys:

- sweetness,
- aroma layering,
- and flavour complexity.

Hotter does not mean better.

4.2 Why Wet Cigars Feel Smooth

Over-humidified cigars often:

- burn cooler,
- feel softer on the palate,
- and suppress harshness.

However, they may also lose:

- flavour definition,

- aromatic clarity,
- combustion efficiency,
- and sweetness expression.

Smoothness alone is not peak performance.

4.3 The Professional Standard

Peak flavour is usually identified by:

- balance,
- controlled combustion,
- stable flavour transitions,
- integrated strength,
- and coherent smoke evolution.

The cigar should feel:

- deliberate,
- structured,
- and controlled,

rather than:

- aggressive,
- muddy,
- or muted.

SECTION 5

FAILURE MODES AROUND PEAK FLAVOUR

5.1 Below Peak RH (Too Dry)

Observable Symptom Likely Cause

Sharp pepper	Excessive combustion heat
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Bitterness	Sugar degradation
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Observable Symptom Likely Cause

Hot smoke	Rapid burn rate
Harsh nicotine delivery	Accelerated volatilization
Weak sweetness	Aromatic destruction

Professional Interpretation

The cigar is combusting too aggressively.

5.2 Above Peak RH (Too Wet)

Observable Symptom Likely Cause

Muted aroma	Suppressed volatilization
Flat sweetness	Incomplete flavour release
Muddy flavours	Low combustion efficiency
Sluggish burn	Excessive moisture load
Uneven combustion	Incomplete ignition stability

Professional Interpretation

The cigar is combusting too coolly and inefficiently.

5.3 Transitional States

Cigars moving toward equilibrium may:

- taste inconsistent,
- improve during the smoke,
- or behave differently between sessions.

This often occurs when:

- the wrapper and filler have not fully equalized,
- or the cigar recently experienced RH change.

Professional diagnosis requires:

- controlled storage,

- proper acclimatization,
 - and accurate RH management.
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SECTION 6

APPLYING THE FRAMEWORK PROFESSIONALLY

6.1 Assigning Peak RH

Professionals evaluate:

- wrapper thickness,
- wrapper oiliness,
- filler density,
- priming selection,
- fermentation style,
- and blender philosophy.

Country of origin alone is not enough to determine optimal smoking RH.

6.2 Using the Framework Diagnostically

When a cigar performs poorly, the sommelier should ask:

1. Is the cigar above or below peak RH?
2. Is the wrapper behaving differently from the filler core?
3. Has the cigar fully equilibrated?

These questions guide corrective action.

6.3 Storage RH vs Smoking RH

The ideal smoking RH may differ from:

- long-term storage RH,
- shipping RH,
- or retail display RH.

This is normal.

Professional cigar management often involves:

- staging,
- acclimatization,
- and preparation before service.

SECTION 7

PEAK FLAVOUR AS A PERFORMANCE SYSTEM

7.1 Why Context Matters

Peak flavour depends on more than humidity alone.

Performance is also affected by:

- cigar construction,
- environmental conditions,
- preparation,
- and smoking cadence.

RH creates the conditions for performance, but smoker technique still matters.

7.2 The Sommelier's Role

The professional sommelier:

- identifies the target RH range,
- stages the cigar correctly,
- confirms equilibration,
- and guides the smoker appropriately.

This is active performance management.

Not passive storage.

SECTION 8

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APPLIED PROFESSIONAL SCENARIOS

Scenario 1 - Harsh Smoke

Customer Complaint

“This cigar feels harsh and overly peppery.”

Professional Diagnosis

Possible under-humidification.

Recommended Action

- Re-equilibrate the cigar,
- reduce combustion aggression,
- and restore moisture balance.

Scenario 2 - Flat Flavour

Customer Complaint

“The cigar feels smooth, but there’s very little flavour.”

Professional Diagnosis

Possible over-humidification.

Recommended Action

- Stage cigar into lower RH range,
- improve combustion efficiency,
- and restore flavour release.

Scenario 3 - Inconsistent Performance

Customer Complaint

“Two cigars from the same box smoked differently.”

Professional Diagnosis

Possible unequal equilibration or RH drift.

Recommended Action

- Stabilize storage conditions,
 - verify equalization,
 - and reassess smoking readiness.
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SECTION 9

EXAMINATION ALIGNMENT

Candidates must be able to:

- define peak flavour accurately,
 - explain why peak flavour exists,
 - distinguish flavour balance from strength,
 - predict RH-related failure modes,
 - and apply the framework diagnostically.
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Common Examination Errors

Candidates often:

- confuse strength with quality,
- assume all cigars perform best at the same RH,
- ignore combustion-temperature effects,
- or rely too heavily on brand reputation.

Professional analysis must remain:

- observational,
 - combustion-based,
 - and causally justified.
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SECTION 10

CORE PROFESSIONAL PRINCIPLES

Candidates should be able to defend the following statements:

1. Peak flavour is a combustion and moisture alignment condition.

2. Flavour deteriorates differently above and below peak RH.
3. Strength, smoothness, and aroma do not automatically indicate peak performance.
4. Small RH changes can significantly affect flavour delivery.
5. Proper cigar performance can be predicted through combustion and moisture understanding.

MODULE SUMMARY

This module establishes that:

- peak flavour exists objectively,
- cigars perform best within narrow RH ranges,
- different cigars require different humidity targets,
- and flavour performance can be managed deliberately.

The professional sommelier therefore moves from:

“This cigar tastes good.”

to:

“This cigar is performing correctly - and I can explain why.”